MalikTrades

WHY I LEFT ICT/SMC

Why I switched to volume profile, and why I'm not going back

THE PLAYBOOK

REASON 01

Real data, not drawn patterns

Every level I trade comes from where volume actually traded.

Before I traded volume profile, I traded **ICT and smart money concepts** on forex. EUR/USD, GBP/JPY and gold, in the London Open Killzone, with three trade models and a long confluence checklist of non-negotiables. I took it seriously, and I put real hours into it.

At its core, **ICT is pattern trading.** Order blocks, fair value gaps, breakers and market structure shifts are all **shapes drawn from candles**. But the market doesn't move because of a candlestick pattern, and there's no hidden algorithm reading the gap between two wicks. Price moves because buyers and sellers are **auctioning to find fair value**.

What changed everything for me was **switching to volume profile trading**. Instead of drawing patterns and guessing what they meant, I could finally see the auction itself: **where contracts actually traded**, where the market found fair value, and where it rejected price. Every level on my chart now comes from **real transactions**, not from my read of a candle. Once I saw that, it was very hard to go back to drawing boxes and gaps.

> *ICT tells you a story about where price should go. Volume profile shows you where the market actually traded.*

PATTERN TRADING VS AUCTION TRADING

ICT / SMC (WHERE I STARTED)

- ✕ Levels drawn from candle patterns: order blocks, gaps, breakers
- ✕ Bias built on a story about where price "should" go
- ✕ Needs a trend and displacement for the patterns to work
- ✕ Two traders can read the same chart completely differently

VOLUME PROFILE (WHAT I TRADE NOW)

- ✓ Levels built from real traded volume: VAH, POC and VAL
- ✓ Trades where price is relative to value, nothing more
- ✓ Works in ranges, breakouts and trends
- ✓ Everyone gets the same levels, so the read is objective

TRY THIS

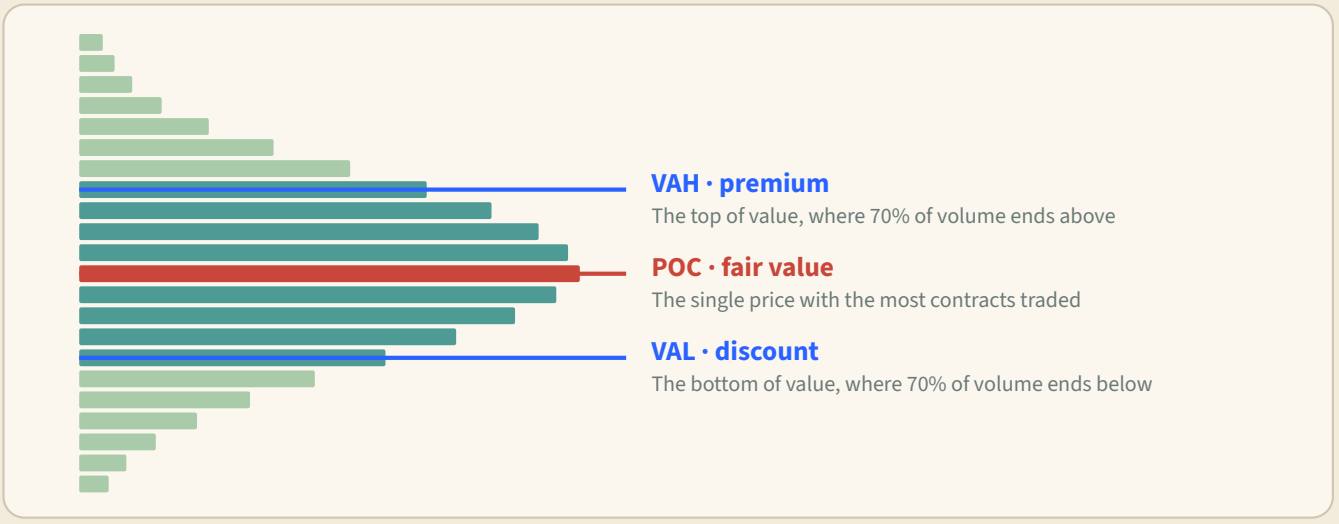
Pull up yesterday's chart and mark it two ways. First, **your ICT levels**: the order blocks and fair value gaps you'd normally draw. Then put a session profile on and mark the **VAH, POC and VAL**. Watch today's session and see **which levels price actually respects**. Do it for a week, and the data will make the argument for me.

REASON 01 · CONTINUED

The same ideas, with and without real data

THE IDEA	HOW ICT FINDS IT	HOW VOLUME PROFILE FINDS IT
Premium and discount	The top and bottom half of a range you choose, often with a Fibonacci tool	The **VAH** and **VAL**: where 70% of the session's volume actually traded
Fair value	A fair value gap: a space between candle wicks	The **POC**: the single price where the most contracts changed hands
Where price reacts	Order blocks and PD arrays, picked from candle shapes	Volume levels and **HVNs**, where the market built real business
Breakouts and fakeouts	Liquidity sweeps and stop hunts, judged after the fact	**Acceptance vs rejection**: does price build volume beyond the level, or snap back?
When to trade	Killzones, with the best setups mostly in one or two windows	Every session builds its own profile, so **Asia, London and NY** all have levels
Why price moves	A narrative about an algorithm delivering price	**Auction market theory**: a two-sided auction looking for fair value

PREMIUM, FAIR VALUE AND DISCOUNT, FROM REAL VOLUME



No ranges to choose and no Fibonacci tool. The profile works out premium, fair value and discount from the contracts that actually traded.

> **The way I see it:** as long as I have the profile on my chart and my value levels marked, I don't need a single candlestick pattern. I trade where price is relative to value, and that's it.

REASON 02

Any market condition

No more waiting for the "right" kind of market.

Spend any time around ICT and SMC traders and you'll hear **the same complaints**. "Price action is too choppy." "This month is lower probability because of the holidays, the news, the range." "You need the market to trend to make money, you can't do much in a range."

That's not bad luck. **It's built into the method.** Pattern trading **needs displacement and a clean trend** to work, so when the market rotates sideways, which it does a lot of the time, **the patterns stop working** and you're told to sit on your hands for weeks.

> *With volume profile, a range isn't a problem. It's a setup.*

EVERY KIND OF DAY HAS A PLAY

WHAT THE MARKET IS DOING	WHAT ICT TENDS TO SAY	WHAT I TRADE
Balanced, rotating day (D-shape)	"Choppy. Lower probability. Wait for a cleaner day."	**The Snap** 👌: fade the VAH and VAL and ping-pong between them until price breaks out of value. This is my favourite day to trade.
Breaking out of value	Wait for a sweep, a shift and a return to an order block	**The Flip** 🔄: once price accepts beyond a level, trade the retest of it from the other side
Trending day (P or b-shape)	The one condition where the patterns work best	**The Magnet** 🧲 back to the dPOC for continuation, or **The Wall** 🧱 off an HVN shelf when there are no levels left
Fake breakout that snaps back	"Liquidity sweep", usually spotted after the fact	**The Whip** ⚡: price breaks dVAH or dVAL with no volume and whips straight back into value
No level in play	Hunt for a pattern somewhere on the chart	**No trade.** No level means no edge, so I wait for price to come to one

The point: I don't need the market to behave a certain way. Whatever it does, the profile tells me where value is, and my setups tell me how to trade around it. There's no such thing as a "bad month" for the method, only for my discipline.

REASON 03

Small moves, all day long

Scalping what's there, instead of waiting for the big one.

From my experience, ICT and SMC need **a long chain of things to happen** before you're allowed to take a trade. You wait for the right session, a liquidity sweep, a market structure shift, a displacement leg, a gap to form, then price to return to it. When it all finally lines up, you're aiming for **one big move**. And **that doesn't happen often.**

I scalp. I take **small moves, level to level, with a 1:1 target**. Those small reactions happen over and over again, **every single day, in every session**.

THE ICT WAY, FROM MY EXPERIENCE

- ✕ Wait for 5 or 6 conditions to line up, in the right order
- ✕ Aim for one big move, often a large multiple of your risk
- ✕ A handful of real setups a week, sometimes fewer
- ✕ Miss one and you wait days for the next
- ✕ Get stopped out and the whole week can feel ruined

THE VOLUME PROFILE WAY

- ✓ Price comes to a level, and I have a plan for it
- ✓ Take a small 1:1 reaction off the level and get out
- ✓ 3–4 setups a session, in Asia, London and NY
- ✓ Miss one and another level is usually close by
- ✓ A loss is one trade out of many, not the whole week

WHY SMALL MOVES WIN

1. **They actually happen.** A reaction of a few points off a real volume level happens many times a day. A huge trend leg doesn't.
2. **They work in any session.** I live in Singapore, so I can **trade the Asia session properly**, not just stay up for New York.
3. **They're easier to repeat.** Same levels, same setups, same 1:1 target, every day. That's what builds consistency, and consistency is what gets you funded.

REASON 04

Confidence and clarity

No more confluences fighting each other.

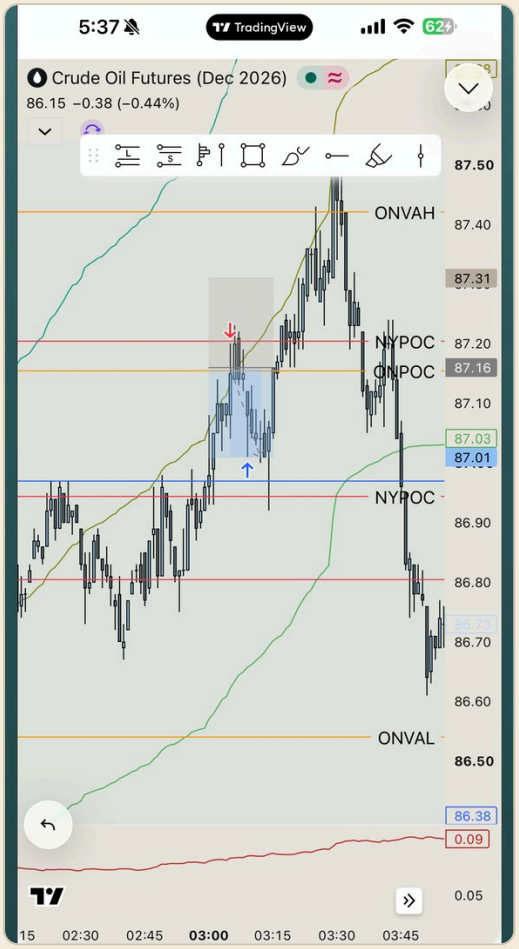
HOW ICT FELT

- ✕ An order block says long, a gap above says short, the killzone hasn't started yet
- ✕ Every chart could be read two ways, depending on which tool you looked at first
- ✕ Getting into a trade without really believing in it
- ✕ Second-guessing entries, exits and the whole bias

HOW VOLUME PROFILE FEELS

- ✓ Every confluence is a level built from real volume, so they stack instead of clash
- ✓ More levels at the same price means a better trade, and a higher star rating
- ✓ A clear plan before price even gets there: entry, stop and target
- ✓ Executing with conviction, because I know why the level matters

WHAT THAT LOOKS LIKE ON A REAL TRADE



1 The levels were there before price was

Crude oil, 12 Nov. The overnight POC, the New York POC and the VWAP band all sat in the same small zone. **Three confluences, stacked.** That's a 3-star Snap.

2 One plan, no conflict

Sell at the ONPOC, with the stop above the NYPOC plus a buffer. **Every confluence agreed:** this was value, and price was coming up into it.

3 The market did its thing

Price pushed into the NYPOC, reacted and rolled over to the downside. **Target hit, +1R.**

4 No second-guessing

No pattern to interpret and no story to believe. Just price coming back to where the market had already done the most business.

REASON 05

The market isn't a puzzle

The most damaging idea I unlearned.

The way ICT is taught makes the market **feel solvable**. There's always another concept to learn, another PDA you didn't spot, another gap at another Fibonacci level. Lose a trade, and the answer is always that **you missed something**.

That mindset is brutal for traders. It turns **every loss into a personal failure** and sends you down an endless rabbit hole looking for the one secret that makes losses stop. **That secret doesn't exist.**

> *You can't solve the market. You can only make good bets, manage your risk, and let the numbers play out.*

Volume profile changed how I think about this. I know I'm trading a **real, data-backed edge**, and I also accept that the market has **a huge amount of randomness** in it. I can have every confluence lined up and **still be wrong**. That doesn't mean I missed something. It means that trade was one of the losers that every edge has.

3–4	65–70%	1:1
setups per session	win rate on my system	risk to reward

With numbers like these, **roughly one trade in three will lose**, and that's built into the plan. **My job isn't to avoid losses.** It's to take every valid setup, size it properly, and let the edge work over **hundreds of trades**.

AFTER A LOSS, THE ICT QUESTION

- ✕ "What did I miss?"
- ✕ "Which concept do I need to learn next?"
- ✕ "Maybe I need a new model."

AFTER A LOSS, MY QUESTION NOW

- ✓ "Was it a valid setup at my level?"
- ✓ "Did I size it by the stars and respect my stop?"
- ✓ If yes to both, move on to the next setup.

REFLECT, DON'T OBSESS

It's still worth reviewing your losses, which is exactly what the weekly self review is for. The question is "did I follow my process?", not "what secret did I miss?". If you followed the plan, a loss is just the cost of doing business.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Why I'm not going back

Five reasons, one conclusion.

1. **Real data, not drawn patterns.** My levels come from where contracts actually traded, not from shapes on candles.
2. **Any market condition.** Ranges, breakouts and trends each have a setup, so I'm never waiting for the right kind of month.
3. **Small moves, all day long.** I scalp 1:1 reactions that happen in every session, instead of waiting days for one big move.
4. **Confidence and clarity.** My confluences stack instead of clash, so I execute without second-guessing.
5. **The market isn't a puzzle.** I trade an edge and accept that losses are part of it, instead of hunting for a secret.

TO BE FAIR

Volume profile isn't magic. You'll still lose trades, you still need risk rules, and you still need the discipline to wait for your levels. It won't fix overtrading or revenge trading on its own. What it gives you is a **clear, objective edge built on real data**, so **the only thing left to work on is you**.

THE BOTTOM LINE

I switched because I wanted to trade what the market is actually doing, not what a pattern says it should do. That one change gave me clarity, confidence and a much healthier relationship with losing.

WHERE TO START

VP Academy #03 · Volume Profile 101

How the auction works, and why our levels matter. Then practise reading levels in the Rep Room.